Comm he conceived his role to be one of assisting in "prodding, questioning, eliciting argument and alternatives and keeping discussion concrete and moving ahead." But because his memos posed for the President the issues, arguments, and questions, his personal reactions mattered.

To the Joint Chiefs of Staff the issue was clear. *Now* was the time to do the job for which they had been preparing contingency plans. The Bay of Pigs was badly done; this round would not be. The missiles provided the *occasion* to deal with the issue for which they were prepared: ridding the Western Hemisphere of Castro's Communism. The security of the United States required a massive air strike, leading to an invasion and the overthrow of Castro. As General Maxwell Taylor, Chairman of the Joint Chiefs, recalls: "I was a twofold Hawk from start to finish, first as a spokesman for the Joint Chiefs of Staff, secondly from personal conviction."[*] While Taylor argued his position carefully, two of the Chiefs advocated military action with an abandon that amazed other members of the Ex Comm. As Robert Kennedy notes, after Air Force Chief of Staff General Curtis LeMay had argued strongly that a military attack was essential, the President asked what the response of the Russians might be. General LeMay replied: "There would be no reaction." The President was not convinced. As he told White House aide Arthur Schlesinger, Jr. on the day the crisis ended, "An invasion would have been a mistake—a wrong use of our power. But the military are mad. They wanted to do this. It's lucky for us we have McNamara over there."

There were other, more persuasive advocates of military action. Acheson, Nitze, Dillon, and McCone found themselves of like mind. Dean Rusk, the Secretary of State, seems to have leaned in their direction. To this group the overriding issues were two: the security of the United States together with its position of leadership in the Western Hemisphere and Western Europe. The situation permitted little time for deliberation. The Soviet missiles in Cuba were fast becoming an acute danger and should be removed by military action before they become operational. In Acheson's words:

> As I saw it at the time, and still believe, the decision to resort to the blockade was a decision to postpone the issue at the expense of time within which the nuclear weapons might be made operational. The Soviet Union did not need to bring any more weapons into Cuba…